



AGENCY FOR HEALTHCARE RESEARCH AND QUALITY



Overview of Insurance Component of the Medical Expenditure Panel Survey MEPS-IC

Anita Soni, PhD, MBA

MEPS-IC OVERVIEW: Outline

MEPS-IC Basics

- Introduction to MEPS-IC
- Purpose and Use
- Sample
- Data Collection
- Type of Information collected
- Survey Form Changes

MEPS-IC Dissemination

- Published Estimates
- Data Tools
- Publications

MEPS-IC Other Information

- Microdata Access
- Contact Information

MEPS Components

Medical Expenditure Panel Survey (MEPS)

Household
Component
(HC)

Medical Provider
Component
(MPC)

Insurance
Component
(IC)

MEPS-Insurance Component (IC)



■ MEPS-IC: Insurance Component

- **Nationwide Survey**
 - **Private Business Establishments**
 - **State and Local Governments**
- **Administered annually since 1996 (except 2007)**
- **Collects data from a sample of private- and public-sector employers on the health insurance plans they offer their employees**
- **An independent survey of employers and unions NOT linked to Household Component**
- **Sponsored by AHRQ and fielded by the U.S. Census Bureau**
- **MEPS-IC is also known as Health Insurance Cost Study**

MEPS-IC: Purpose

- **MEPS-IC fields questionnaires to private and public sector employers to collect data on:**
 - **Percent of employers offering health insurance**
 - **Plans offered by the employers**
 - **Average premiums, contributions, and deductibles**
 - **Employee eligibility**
 - **Number of enrollees**
- **Produces estimates at national, state, and metro-area level for:**
 - **Private Corporations**
 - **State and Local Governments (not Federal Government)**
 - **Civilians**

MEPS-IC: Use

- **MEPS-IC estimates are used by:**
 - **U.S. Bureau of Economic Analysis – used in production of Gross Domestic Product (GDP)**
 - **National Health Accounts**
 - **U.S. Treasury – Health insurance tax model**
 - **Joint House/Senate Taxation Committee**
 - **Congressional Budget Office/Congressional Research Service**
 - **Many other Federal and State government agencies**

MEPS-IC: Sample

- **Sample of private establishments drawn from Census Bureau's Business Register**
 - Over 42,000 establishments (individual locations)
 - Establishments chosen over firms for survey unit
 - Firms can cross state boundaries
 - Large firms can be very diverse
- **Sample of State and local governments (no federal) drawn from Census Bureau's:**
 - Governments Master Address File and Census of Governments
 - Approximately 3,000 governmental units sampled
- **New sample selected annually**

MEPS-IC Sample Sizes

MEPS-IC Sample Size

Year	Private sector establishments			State and local government units
	Total	Single	Multi	
2024	42,519	19,957	22,562	
2023	42,465	20,442	22,023	3,260
2022	39,969	18,425	21,544	3,264
2021	39,935	19,160	20,775	3,233
2020	40,605	19,871	20,734	3,327
2019	40,451	19,560	20,891	3,362
2018	40,025	20,819	19,206	3,193
2017	40,044	20,865	19,179	3,611
2016	39,751	20,926	18,825	3,028
2015	39,646	24,288	15,358	2,999
2014	39,002	23,851	15,151	2,928
2013	39,216	23,917	15,299	2,980
2012	39,034	23,877	15,157	2,912
2011	39,351	24,358	14,993	3,017
2010	38,409	23,641	14,768	3,090
2009	38,379	23,881	14,498	3,030
2008	38,754	26,313	12,441	3,058

MEPS-IC: Data Collection

■ Multiple data collections methods are used

➤ Stage 1: Prescreener/Pre canvass

- Telephone call to sample units
- Confirm contact information for sample units offering insurance
- For non-offering sample units – completion of survey
- Collect email address

➤ Stage 2: Letter/Form mail-out

- Letter and email sent with web address to fill forms online, using secure web tool
- If no answer received, forms sent to contact (one for sample unit and one for each plan offered)
- Respondents may return paper forms or fill out forms online
- Web primary mode of data collection, mail mode is used as follow-up

➤ Stage 3: Telephone follow up

- Computer Assisted Telephone Interview (CATI) for sample unit that don't return paper/web forms
- Secure messaging; reminder Robocalls

Types of Information Collected

■ Private Sector

- Firm-level (company) characteristics
- Establishment-level (single physical location) characteristics
- Health insurance plan characteristics

■ Public Sector

- Same questions for governmental units, but unit is all sites under a single controlling governmental entity, such as county-wide school system

Establishment-level Characteristics

- **Number of active employees**
- **Health insurance offered or not**
- **Number of plans offered**
- **Number of employees**
 - **eligible for health insurance**
 - **enrolled (full-time and part-time employees separately)**
- **Workforce characteristics (percent of women, union status, over 50 years old, by wage level)**
- **Offers of tax-advantaged and supplemental benefits**

Firm (Company)-level Characteristics

- **Employment size**
- **Industry**
- **Age of firm**
- **Retiree health insurance offerings**

Health Insurance Plan Characteristics

- **Active enrollment (single, employee-plus-one, family coverage)**
- **Premiums (single, employee-plus-one, family)**
- **Cost sharing – employee/employer**
- **Plan types, by provider arrangement**
- **Self-Insured / 3rd party insurance**
- **Deductibles / Co-payments**
- **COBRA enrollment**
- **Limited information on plan benefits (prescription medicine)**
- **HSAs and HRAs availability**

MEPS-IC: Form Changes

- **MEPS-IC survey forms**
 - Updated annually to capture new data and monitor changes
- **Examples of added questions in last five years**
 - Added Individual Coverage Health Reimbursement Arrangement (ICHRA) to question on Qualified Small Employer Health Reimbursement Arrangement
 - Added critical illness insurance to question on fringe benefits

Revisions to Existing Questions

- **Revisions to existing questions**
 - **Wording for question on optional coverage services**
 - **Wording for question on actuarial value**
 - **Wording for header on fringe benefits**
 - **Remove question on maximum out-of-pocket for specialty drugs**
 - **Revised wording for question on COBRA enrollment**
 - **Revised wording for question on HRA**

MEPS-IC: Dissemination



https://meps.ahrq.gov/mepsweb/survey_comp/Insurance.jsp

- **Sample Design**
- **Data Collection Process**
- **Technical Notes**
- **Survey Questionnaires**
- **Statistical Briefs analyzing estimates from tables**
- **Methodology Reports**
- **Publications**
- **Table Series in PDF**
- **Tables in Excel Spreadsheet**
- **MEPS-IC Data Tools**

MEPS-IC on the Web



[Search All AHRQ Sites](#) | [Careers](#) | [Contact Us](#) | [Español](#) | [FAQs](#) | [Email Updates](#)



Medical Expenditure Panel Survey

[Contact MEPS](#) [MEPS FAQ](#) [MEPS Site Map](#)

Search MEPS

Go

Font Size:

[S](#) [M](#) [L](#) [XL](#)

[Home](#) > [Survey Showcards](#) > [Survey Questionnaires](#) > [Insurance/Employer](#)

[printer-friendly](#)

[MEPS Home](#)

[About MEPS](#)

- [Survey Background](#)
- [Workshops & Events](#)
- [Data Release Schedule](#)

[Survey Components](#)

- [Household](#)
- [Insurance/Employer](#)
- [Medical Provider](#)
- [Survey Questionnaires](#)

[Data and Statistics](#)

- [Data Overview](#)
- [MEPS Topics](#)
- [Publications Search](#)
- [MEPS Data Tools \(HC/IC\)](#)
- [Data Files](#)
- [Data Centers](#)

[Communication](#)

- [What's New](#)

Insurance/Employer Component

The MEPS Insurance Component fields questionnaires to private and public sector employers to collect data on the private health insurance plans offered, benefits, annual premiums, annual contributions by employers and employees, eligibility, and employer characteristics.

MEPS-IC Data Tools and Tables

[MEPS-IC data tools](#): Maps, trends, and cross-sectional bar charts for topics related to national and state-level employer-based health insurance for employer characteristics/offerings; employee take-up; premiums; contributions; and cost-sharing:

- [Private sector - National](#)
- [Private sector - State](#)
- [Private sector - Metro areas](#)
- [Public Sector](#)
- [Civilian](#)

[Complete Table Series PDFs](#): Access PDF tables with frequently used data on employer-based health insurance.

[State tables in Spreadsheet format](#): Download Excel files of 1-year and 3-year private-sector data by state.

MEPS-IC: Published Estimates



- **Private-Sector tables provide estimates by firm size, industry group, census region, and other characteristics at the Metropolitan Area levels. Estimates for every State since 2003.**
- **Public-Sector tables provide estimates by state and local government type, government size, and census division.**
- **Civilian-Sector estimates incorporate both the private and state and local government sectors.**

MEPS-IC: Published Estimates



■ Private sector

- **More than 500 tables of National, State, and MSA estimates released each July; all include standard errors**
 - **Premiums and contributions**
 - **Offers and employee eligibility**
 - **Enrollments and take-up rates**
 - **Others (i.e., percent of employees offered more than one plan; deductible and copayment amounts)**
 - **New tables often added each year.**
 - **In 2025 (for survey year 2024), 35 new tables were added.**
 - **Total 610 tables were released for private sector.**

MEPS-IC: Published Estimates



- **Governments (State and Local) and Civilian**
 - **Approximately 200 tables of National and Census Division estimates released each November; all include standard errors**
 - **Premiums and Contributions**
 - **Deductibles and Copayments**
 - **Others (i.e., contributions to health savings account, third party insurance)**
 - **New tables often added each year.**
 - **In 2024 (for survey year 2023), 221 tables were released**
 - **Tables for survey year 2024 will be released in November**

MEPS-IC: Published Estimates



- **National and State-level estimates are produced by:**
 - **Firm Size**
 - **Industry Groupings**
 - **Ownership Type (for profit; non-profit)**
 - **Age of Firm**
 - **Proportion of Employees by the following:**
 - **Full-time**
 - **Low-wage**
 - **Women**
 - **Age 50 or older**
 - **Average Wage Quartiles**
- **National only:**
 - **Union status**
 - **One or multiple locations for firm**

MEPS-IC: Published Estimates



- The MEPS-IC Data tables can be downloaded https://meps.ahrq.gov/data_stats/summ_tables/meps-ic-table-series.shtml
- The data tables can be downloaded in Excel as well as PDF formats.

MEPS-IC: Data Tools



<https://datatools.ahrq.gov/meps-ic>

**Agency for Healthcare
Research and Quality**

Search All AHRQ Sites | Careers | Contact Us | Español | FAQs |  Email Updates

Data Tools Home | CAHPS | HCUP Fast Stats | HCUPnet | MEPS-HC | MEPS-IC | NHQDR | Resources

[AHRQ Data Tools](#) > MEPS-IC Data Tools



Search Across Data Tools

Medical Expenditure Panel Survey (MEPS) Insurance Component (IC)

Information from the private sector and State and local governments on the health insurance coverage offered to their employees.

For more information about MEPS, visit meps.ahrq.gov

AHRQ Data Tools +

What's New

Explore the MEPS-IC Data Tools

The Medical Expenditure Panel Survey Insurance Component (MEPS-IC) is an annual survey of private employers and State and local governments. The MEPS-IC produces national and State level estimates of employee coverage.

Private Sector - National Private sector National-level data by firm size, industry group, census region, and other characteristics. Table Series I	Private Sector - State Private sector data by firm size, state, industry groupings, ownership type, age of firm, employee characteristics, and average wage quartiles. Table Series II, V-VIII, X, XII	Private - Metropolitan Area Private sector data for the 20 largest metro areas by firm size and at least one metro area in each state along with data for the remainder of that state. Table Series IX	Public Sector Public sector data by state and local government type, government size, and census division. Table Series III, IV	Civilian Civilian estimates incorporating both the private and state and local government sectors. Table Series IV, XI
---	--	--	---	--

MEPS-IC: Publications



- **Miller, E., Keenan, P., Vistnes, J.**
“Potential Exposure of Enrollees in Private-Sector Employer-Sponsored Insurance to Out-of-Pocket Costs, 2006 to 2017”
International Health Economics Association

<https://healtheconomics.confex.com/healtheconomics/2019/meetingapp.cgi/Paper/3556>

- **Cooper, P.F. and Manski, R.J.**
“Enrollment trends in employer-sponsored health plans that include dental benefits”
The Journal of the American Dental Association

<https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S0002817721000945>

- **Zawacki, A., Hegland, T., and Miller, G. E.**
“Telemedicine Coverage Under Employer-Sponsored Health Insurance Plans”

International Health Economics Association

<https://healtheconomics.confex.com/healtheconomics/2021/meetingapp.cgi/Paper/6207>

Microdata Access: Data Centers



■ Microdata files access

Available only from Census Bureau RDCs

- **Purpose:** Provide researchers access to MEPS-IC microdata files
- **Access:** Data can be accessed through Federal Statistical Research Data Centers (FSRDC)
<https://www.census.gov/about/adrm/fsrdc.html>
- **Locations:** FSRDC has partnerships between other federal statistical agencies and leading research institutions through out the U.S.

Census Bureau Research Data Centers (RDC)



- **Formal Research Application Process**
- **Fee for Using Data Centers**
- **All Output Reviewed for Confidentiality**
 -  **Regression Analysis**
 -  **Table Output**
- **AHRQ supports and encourages research proposals using MEPS-IC**
- ***WWW.CENSUS.GOV / FSRDC***

MEPS-IC: Contact Information



For MEPS questions:

mepsprojectdirector@ahrq.hhs.gov

For AHRQ Data Center questions:

CFACTDC@AHRQ.HHS.GOV

For FSRDC questions:

<https://www.census.gov/about/adrm/fsrdc/contact.html>

For MEPS Workshops or Webinars questions:

WorkshopInfo@ahrq.hhs.gov

Thank you!



Anita.Soni@ahrq.hhs.gov